St. Genevieve Community Church

All Saints Day - November 1, 2026
"The Work of All Saints"
Rev. Colette Mullins, Rector

Scripture Readings

Revelation 7:9-17 - After this I looked, and there was a great multitude that no one could count, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, robed in white, with palm branches in their hands.

Matthew 5:1-12 - When Jesus saw the crowds, he went up the mountain; and after he sat down, his disciples came to him. Then he began to speak, and taught them, saying: Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

Sermon

There is a painting I keep in my mind when I think about this day, All Saints Day. It is not a painting from a gallery, but one I have watched my congregation build together, Sunday by Sunday, year after year. It is the painting of ordinary faithfulness: the elder who greets at the door in every weather, the young parent who brings a restless toddler to the font, the retired teacher who stays to stack the chairs.

That is what I want to say to you today, on this feast of All Saints: sainthood is not a category reserved for the medieval or the martyred. It is a calling woven into the fabric of ordinary life. The Beatitudes do not describe an elite spiritual class. They describe a posture, a way of moving through the world.

I. Saints Are Made, Not Born

Augustine, writing in his Confessions at the end of the fourth century, did not set out to be a saint. He set out to be admired, to be successful, to satisfy a restlessness he could not name. "Our heart is restless," he wrote, "until it rests in Thee." The entire arc of his life was a formation: uncomfortable, sometimes humiliating, always incomplete.

The Book of Common Prayer carries this wisdom into our practice. The Daily Office, Morning Prayer and Evening Prayer, is not a performance. It is a scaffold. It holds us in relationship to the divine Word even when we feel nothing, even when we arrive distracted or grieving.

II. Sainthood Lives in the Mundane

I think of Eleanor Hartwell, who sang in this choir for forty years and died in the autumn of last year. Eleanor was not famous. She never preached a sermon or chaired a committee. She came to choir practice on Thursday evenings for four decades. She learned the soprano line for every anthem. She showed up. That is sainthood.

Gregory of Nyssa wrote of epektasis, the eternal stretching of the soul toward God. Saints are not those who have arrived. They are those who keep stretching.

III. We Are the Company We Keep

The cloud of witnesses in Revelation is not distant from us. It is present. Those we have lost remain part of our congregation. When we gather at this table, we gather with all of them, with every generation that has

worshipped in this building since 1924. We are one congregation across time.

Closing Prayer

Holy God, you have called us each by name into this great company of the faithful. May we live this week as the saints you have named us to be, in the daily bread of kindness, the wine of perseverance, and the bread broken for those who hunger. Amen.

Hymns: For All the Saints (Hymnal 1982, No. 287); I Sing a Song of the Saints of God (No. 293)